

As already mentioned, CF makes it easier to distinguish between values by using visual cues. CF allows a cell to be formatted in all possible combinations. This includes cell colour, font colour, font size, font style, and more. It even adds a new type of formatting that involves the use of icon to distinguish between cells. While there are a lot of formatting options, the “condition” options are almost as varied. CF supports conditions like greater than or less than, equal or unequal, duplicates or uniques. It can also check for non-numerical conditions, like the presence of certain text or a date. Any user-created formula that returns a logical value can also be used as the criterion in CF.



Conditional Formatting menu

CF is accessed from the Home Tab under the Styles Block. Since CF applies to a range of cells, it is expected that a range of cells be selected before using CF. The formatting capabilities under conditional formatting can be broadly divided into two types. These are as follows.

2.5.1 Formatting All Cells in a range based on their Values

This would result in all cells in a range being given some visual cue based on certain criteria. CF comes preloaded with three types of format styles for this category: Colour Scales, Data Bars, and Icon sets. By default, selecting a range of cells and applying any of these CF styles will cause Excel to calculate the maximum and minimum values in that range and apply the corresponding visual cue. Data Bars involves displaying a bar in the cell, with the cell value determining the bar length. The resulting effect is similar to plotting a bar graph right in the column. A Colour Scale uses a two or three-colour colouring scheme, with the mix of the colours being controlled by the cell value. An Icon set uses a set of three, four or five icons to convey the information, with the value of the cell determining the colour/type of icon used.